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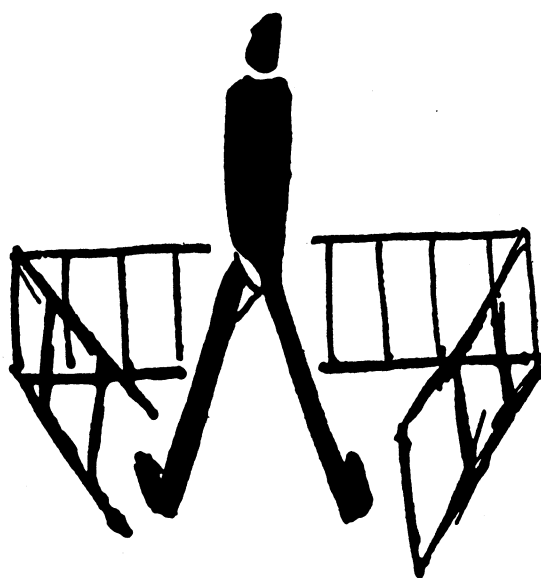
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Kafka's Parable *Before the Law*: Reflections towards a Positive Interpretation



By JÜRGEN BORN

In December, 1915, there appeared in the almanac of Kurt Wolff Publishers a series of samples from the works of contemporary authors. Among these was a two-page prose selection by Franz Kafka entitled "Before the Law."¹ The author's diary (December

¹*Vom jüngsten Tag. Ein Almanach neuer Dichtung* (Leipzig, 1916), pp. 126-128.

The interpretation in the paper rests on this, the first publication of the text. The later version of the parable, published posthumously in the novel, *The Trial*, deviates somewhat in wording and punctuation. The exposition which follows the parable in *The Trial* will not be considered here. Its function in the novel is through refined pettifoggery to dissolve the message of the parable into nothing. It is Josef K. who introduces and continues the exposition through his questions. In keeping with his "classifying mind," the paradoxes of the parable are spun into the infinite, until in the end the "simple story" loses its "clear outline," and finally Josef K. himself is "too tired" to be able "to survey all the conclusions arising from the story." *Der Prozess*, Frankfurt am Main, 1950, p. 264.

Among the analyses which consider the author's own "exegesis" of the parable are such comprehensive studies of Kafka's works as W. Emrich, *Franz Kafka*, Bonn, 1957; H. Politzer, *Franz Kafka: Parable and Paradox*, Ithaca, N.Y., 1962; W. H. Sokel, *Franz Kafka—Tragik und Ironie*, München, Wien, 1964. In addition the reader's attention is called to the following more specific studies: I. Henel, "Die Türhüterlegende und ihre Bedeutung für Kafka: 'Prozess'," *Deutsche Vierteljahrsschrift* (1963), pp. 50 ff., and H. Deinert, "Kafka's Parable *Before the Law*," *Germanic Review*, Vol. XXXIX, No. 3 (May 1964), pp. 192 ff.

13, 1914) indicated that this piece was written approximately one year earlier during the composition of the novel, *The Trial*. Whereas this novel was first published in 1925 (by Max Brod) one year after the author's death, the "Legend of the Doorkeeper," as Kafka entitled his parable "Before the Law," was published twice during Kafka's lifetime.

Apart from this prose selection there is only one other portion of *The Trial* manuscript which the author was prepared to publish, namely "A Dream." Thus this portion is one of the few of his works which he himself considered successful. His diary contains what for Kafka is a rare admission—that he experienced "a feeling of satisfaction and happiness . . . regarding the Legend."² Kafka, his own most severe and unrelenting critic, knew that in the composition of this "legend" he had created a piece of prose of which he himself could approve. Therefore, he did not hesitate to extract it from *The Trial* manuscript and publish it independently.

Though this parable had grown out of the novel, indeed forms an integral part of it, its significance reaches far beyond the boundaries of the novel itself. It rises above the action described in *The Trial* and becomes a symbol of the human situation as Kafka saw it.

The central figure of the parable is a "man from the country," without education or experience. This man's highest ambition, the goal of all his striving, is to enter into the Law. However, before the Law stands a doorkeeper who denies him admittance, and explains to him that he cannot now grant him entry. The man then seeks to catch a glimpse of the interior of the Law, so that at least his eyes may penetrate to where he dare not direct his step. The doorkeeper becomes aware of this and explains: "If you are so strongly tempted, try to get in without my permission. But note, I am powerful. And I am only the lowest doorkeeper. From hall to hall, keepers stand at every door, one more powerful than the other. Not even I can bear the sight of the third one."

With this statement something decisive has been said about the Law: a vast expanse of halls which cannot be captured in a glance, each with a strictly guarded entrance, separates the man from his actual goal—the innermost room of the Law. A similar situation obtains in Kafka's parable, "An Imperial Message," where endless distances and infinite numbers of obstacles separate the emperor's messenger from his goal—the one awaiting the message.

The statements of the doorkeeper regarding the obstacles on the way to the interior of the Law, as well as the appearance of the doorkeeper himself—his large pointed nose, the long slender, black Tartar beard—dismiss from the mind of the man from the country every thought of seeking entrance on his own. Rather he decides to wait for permission to enter. Of course, in the succeeding days and years which he spends in waiting, he makes many efforts to be

²Franz Kafka, *Tagebuecher 1910-1932*, Frankfurt am Main, 1951, p. 448.

allowed entry, but these attempts are no more than hesitant requests of the doorkeeper to grant him permission. He never exercises personal initiative.

The first words of the doorkeeper have already robbed the man of independent action. As though paralyzed he sits off to the side on a stool which the doorkeeper has provided. He spends everything he has brought with him for his journey in attempting to bribe the doorkeeper. The doorkeeper accepts all the gifts, but explains that he is doing so only to keep the man from feeling that he has "left something undone." The irony of these words becomes clear only at the conclusion of the parable, because at that point the man is a long way toward neglecting the most important thing of all, namely entrance into the Law.

The turn that now takes place is worthy of particular consideration. The man, who during the many years of waiting has constantly been observing the first doorkeeper, now forgets the others inside. He comes to regard this first one as the only obstacle to his entrance into the Law. This is a significant psychological factor. In the eyes of the one who has waited for years, the first doorkeeper grows to gigantic proportions and virtually blocks the view of the waiting man. Like one mesmerized, he gazes at the first doorkeeper, thus losing more and more the wider perspective, as does Josef K. in *The Trial*. The man's perspective is constricted even further. During his years of intense study of the doorkeeper the man becomes aware of the fleas in the doorkeeper's fur collar. In a gesture of senile childishness he finally requests the fleas to change the doorkeeper's mind. Thus by degrees the man from the country loses more and more the vision of his real goal. He hardly dares any longer to think of entry into the Law.

Finally the man's vision becomes impaired. He is not sure whether the surrounding darkness is an objective condition or whether his weakened eyes are deceiving him. Yet in this darkness, whatever its cause may be, he perceives a "radiance that streams inextinguishably from the door of the Law."

Now that he has presentiments of his impending death, "all the experiences of his entire time of waiting" accumulate in his mind and issue in one question. To the doorkeeper he says: "Everyone strives to attain the Law, why then has no one beside me sought admittance in these many years?" Unwillingly, and almost as though he himself had experienced a severe disappointment, the doorkeeper bellows his devastating answer into the ear of the man who has by now become hard of hearing: "No one but you could have gained entry here, because this door was intended for you alone. I am now going to shut it."

Let us bring to mind again the psychological process underlying the action. Before the man from the country came to the gateway of the Law, he obviously believed that the Law was "accessible to

everyone and at all times." The appearance of the doorkeeper and the ensuing verbal exchange set in motion a psychological process in which this idea (or belief) vanishes by stages. The man seats himself on a stool; that is, his external progress toward the Law comes to a complete standstill as well. His gaze, directed initially to the entrance of the Law, wanders to the doorkeeper, and finally settles on the very fleas in his fur collar.

The end of this psychic regression is described in the parable by the following statement: "The difference in size between them has increased very much to the man's disadvantage." Colloquial speech has an expression for this. One might say that the man at the conclusion of the story feels very "small" in the presence of the doorkeeper; Kafka's statement, however, describes a second phenomenon. Not only has the man become small, but, as a consequence of this, the doorkeeper has grown to enormous size. What transpires outwardly in the action of the parable is a reflection of the psychic process in the dialogue between the man and the doorkeeper. Kafka's writings present, as Wilhelm Emrich once put it, "philosophical, emotional, and psychological truths . . . as sensuously perceptible realities."³

II

"Whoever yields to the temptation to follow this book in parallel fashion, will be drawn downstream. Essentially it will delight only those who undertake to read it against the stream, as it were." Rainer Maria Rilke prefaced his *Notebook of Malte Laurids Brigge* with this warning. Our attempt at a positive interpretation of Kafka's parable is in effect an attempt to interpret it in accordance with Rilke's words by reading it "against the stream."

We proceed from the premise that Josef K., the main character in *The Trial*, is guilty. From the author's diary it is clear that Kafka, his creator, considered him guilty.⁴ To be sure, Josef K. himself never becomes actually conscious of his guilt. What he experiences is only a feeling of guilt, but this suffices to call forth from the depths of his unconscious the horrible punishment-fantasies which fill the novel. Of course, Kafka never described these fantasies of Josef K. as fantasies, but rather presented them as "sensuously perceptible realities."

In *The Trial* it is the prison chaplain who tells the parable. In doing so he holds a mirror to Josef K.'s face, but the latter does not recognize himself in it. To be sure, he is strongly attracted by the story, but he is not aware that it is intended for him, and that it is his own story. "Mere legends cannot alter my opinion," he had told the painter Titorelli, when this gentleman had wanted to report of

³"Die Bilderwelt Franz Kafkas," *Akzente* 2 (April 1960), pp. 172 ff.

✓ ⁴*Tagebuecher*, *op. cit.*, p. 481.

legends which had been preserved concerning former legal proceedings.⁵ If the situation of the man from the country is analogous to that of Josef K. in *The Trial*, then we may assume that the man from the country is guilty as well. We conjecture that he is guilty—of an omission.

We presuppose further that the parable does not deal with genuine contradictions to which the term *principium contradictionis* would apply, but rather with paradoxes which may indeed be apparent contradictions. Such paradoxes inevitably confuse Josef K., the managing clerk of a bank and habitual calculator. It is these paradoxes, too, which (at least initially) confuse the reader who trusts his logic. If, however, we are dealing with apparent contradictions, then we have a right to enquire how the man from the country should have behaved in order to gain admittance to the Law.

In this connection we turn once again to the text of the parable. We would have a genuine contradiction on our hands if the doorkeeper had said to the man, "You may never, never enter here," and in the same breath, "This door was intended only for you." But this is not the case. In the first place he never categorically denies the man entry. He merely states that he cannot "now" grant him permission, but he holds out the hope of a possible future entry. Indeed, he finally encourages him to enter: "If you are so strongly tempted, try to get in without my permission." Of course, he appends the exhortation with a warning: "But note, I am powerful. And I am only the lowest doorkeeper. From hall to hall, keepers stand at every door, one more powerful than the other." Yet the warning does not amount to an explicit revocation.

The man from the country, discouraged by the warning and the fearful appearance of the doorkeeper, decides rather to wait until the permission is granted. Wait rather than—what? What is the alternative implied in the comparison, we may well ask. Kafka does not say, but the only possible alternative is to enter without permission, precisely the action which the doorkeeper had suggested (though with obvious irony).

Was it necessary for the doorkeeper to say more to the man than he did? Should he have told him at the outset that this entrance was intended solely for him? No. From the final words of the doorkeeper it is clear that the parable presupposes, without saying it, that each person can find entrance to the Law only through the gate which is destined for him. In other words, the man should have known that this was his entrance. There is no possibility here for an "unfortunate coincidence." The man should never have questioned, let alone surrendered, the idea (or belief), that the Law was "accessible to everyone and at all times." In a word, he should have entered, in defiance of all the discouragements from the door-

⁵Franz Kafka, *Der Prozess*, *op. cit.*, p. 186.

keeper.⁶

If the doorkeeper is telling the truth when he says that "from hall to hall, keepers stand at every door, one more powerful than the other," then his statement describes an endless series of obstacles, more than can be captured at a glance. Yet this does not imply that it is necessary to overcome *all* the obstacles in order to gain access to the Law. Nor is it absolutely necessary that one attain to the innermost room.

"There were obstacles, as there always are; but then, life consists in taking such obstacles." With these words Kafka, in his famous "Letter to His Father," answers the question he himself had posed: "Why, then, did I not marry?"⁷ If we apply Kafka's words, "Life consists in overcoming obstacles," to the parable, then the way into the interior of the Law, depicted by the doorkeeper, corresponds to the way of life itself. The Law about which the parable speaks need not, therefore, be an ultimate which one must necessarily attain. It seems rather that the law of life enjoins striving for this ultimate, that is, overcoming the obstacles, which are too numerous to comprehend and, in the final analysis, quite possibly invincible. Had the man from the country set out upon this way, we conjecture, the Law would have become his portion.

A word now regarding the doorkeeper and his attitude toward the man from the country. Why, we may well ask, does he allow the life of the waiting man to slip by unfulfilled between the "not yet" and the "no longer"? "Test yourself by humanity," says an aphorism of Kafka. "Humanity makes the doubter doubt, the believer believe."⁸ The doorkeeper must, as it were, of necessity deny entry to the doubting, the indecisive, the discouraged. He is not in a position to determine whether one is entitled to enter or not, because he does not represent an autonomous power. *His power (or lack of it) depends totally on the inner stance of the one desiring admittance.*

From this perspective the Josef K. fragment acquires significance in that it is said of these "mute subordinate persons" that they do "everything one presupposes they will do. . . . If I anticipate that he [the doorkeeper] will observe me with inappropriate looks, he will actually do so."⁹

⁶Thus far only Walter Muschg has so unequivocally expressed the opinion that the man should have entered without fear. *Die Zerstörung der deutschen Literatur*, 3rd expanded edition, 1958, p. 212. This paper seeks to test the validity of his assertion.

⁷Franz Kafka, *Hochzeitsvorbereitungen auf dem Lande und andere Prosa aus dem Nachlass*, Frankfurt am Main, 1953, p. 216.

⁸*Hochzeitsvorbereitungen*, *op. cit.*, p. 47.

⁹*Tagebuecher*, *op. cit.*, p. 414. Kafka describes the doorkeeper also as "mute" (here he calls him a "watchman") in this enlightening variation of the parable. The first person pronoun is used here, and seems to have reference to a dream of the author:

I overran the first watchman. Subsequently I became fearful, ran back, and said to the watchman, "I ran through here while you were turned away." The watchman looked straight ahead and was silent. "Perhaps I should not have done it," I said. The watchman remained silent. "Does your silence indicate permission to proceed?" p. 359.

Those entitled to admittance establish their right by proceeding through the door despite the doorkeeper's warning. Therefore, the doorkeeper cannot be expected to inform the man that this entrance is designed especially for him, at least not while there remains the slightest possibility of his entering. The one seeking entry either knows this unwaveringly, or he does not know it, and thereby pronounces his own verdict. Thus it is actually not the doorkeeper who denies admittance, but personal fear and the doubt and indecision which follow it. The most important, and certainly the most difficult, test for the man from the country is overcoming his own fear and doubt in the presence of the doorkeeper. The sole purpose of the doorkeeper is, by his fearful presence and his discouraging words, to test the man seeking admittance.

If we read Kafka's legend "against the stream, as it were," then we conceive of it differently from Josef K., who trusts his "calmly classifying mind." The supposed contradictions then turn out to be only *apparent* contradictions—paradoxes. It is a paradox and not a contradiction when the doorkeeper denies the man admittance at the outset and reveals to him only at the end that this entrance was intended for him alone. Without doubt the entrance was intended for him, but he should have entered on his own initiative and not waited for explicit permission. Nor is it surprising that the doorkeeper at the conclusion sets about to lock the entrance. Since this entrance to the Law was intended specifically for the man from the country, now dying before the door, no one else will enter here.

III

Seen from the perspective of depth psychology, the doorkeeper is doubtless a father image who bars his son's entry into the gate of life. In actual fact the relationship of the man to the doorkeeper portrays a father fixation. In remarkable fascination the gaze of the man from the country fixes upon the doorkeeper. He dedicates to this figure a study of many years' duration, a study from which he is not freed even at the end.

Kafka's "Letter to His Father," which can be described as the product of a father-study of many years' duration, would support such an interpretation.¹⁰ The letter speaks significantly of Kafka's attempt to free himself from his father. The father was sympathetic toward this attempt, but in actuality it turned out to be "like the children's game in which one holds and even grips the other's hand, calling out: 'Oh, go away, go away, why don't you go away?' Which in our case happens to be complicated by the fact that you have always honestly meant this 'go away!' and have always unknowingly held me, or rather held me down, only by the strength of your

¹⁰Kafka here describes his "breaking away" from his father," (which, of course, could never be done completely)." *Hochzeitsvorbereitungen*, *op. cit.*, p. 195.

personality."¹¹

Is this not in effect the function of the doorkeeper? Is not the man from the country held by the doorkeeper, or more correctly, held down by him? And does not the father's encouragement correspond to the words of the doorkeeper, "If you are enticed by it, try it"?

"It is altogether a remarkable error," Kafka writes in another part of the letter, "if you believe that I never fell in with your wishes. . . . On the contrary, if I had obeyed you less, I am sure you would have been much better pleased with me."¹² The same paradox occurs here as in Kafka's story of the doorkeeper. If the man from the country had followed the doorkeeper less, if he had entered into the Law without permission, he would have done what was right. Indeed, the anger of the doorkeeper at the conclusion of the legend certainly suggests that he too would have been "much better pleased" if the man had dared to enter. As little as we would be justified in seeing in the legend solely and alone Kafka's artistic formulation of the conflict between him and his father, so little may we doubt that this conflict is indeed reflected in the story of the doorkeeper.¹³

Certain elements of the parable suggest a metaphysical or religious interpretation. Kafka has designated the story of the doorkeeper as a *legend*. Perhaps he was thinking primarily of the unreal and the unusual, both of which are characteristic of a legend. Yet, with reference to *The Trial*, the designation "legend" regains its original meaning, namely that of a religiously edifying and didactic narrative. In *The Trial* the story is told in a church building by a clergyman.

The metaphysical is suggested in the broad expanses, and perhaps in the endless distances, which seem to separate the man from the country from the inner sanctum: "From hall to hall, keepers stand at every door, one more powerful than the other." Furthermore, it is said of the Law that it is to be "accessible for everyone and at all times." For days and years, indeed all his life, the man from the country sits outside the Law waiting, and toward the end of the legend he recognizes in the darkness "a radiance that streams inextinguishably from the door of the Law." All of this seems to point to something absolute. Indeed, we would like to believe that if a second possibility does exist for the man from the country to enter into the Law, this possibility must consist of waiting with patient endurance at the door of the Law, in the unshakable hope that the doorkeeper, perhaps urged to do so by some higher power, will some day open the way. Unfortunately for the "heroes" (and the interpreters), there is in Kafka always a second possibility. Unwavering,

¹¹*Hochzeitsvorbereitungen*, op. cit., p. 215.

¹²*Ibid.*, p. 175.

¹³In one of his letters to Felice Bauer Kafka writes about his father: "If need be, I could get past him, but never stride over him." *Briefe an Felice*, Frankfurt am Main, 1967, p. 452.

patient waiting may also lead into the Law. We might find an interpretation of the legend in the words of Kafka, "He who seeks does not find, but he who does not seek, will be found,"¹⁴ or in the words of Block, the merchant in *The Trial* (if we may trust his words), "Waiting is not useless, . . . the only useless thing is to take action independently."¹⁵

But even for this alternative of patient waiting the attitude of the man is not sufficiently consistent. He soon gives up the idea that the Law is "accessible to everyone and at all times." He wearies the doorkeeper with his persistent requests, and finally attempts to bribe him. In a word, he does not remain unwavering in his faith, but seeks to achieve admittance through his own intervention. Such action reveals his doubting only too clearly.

Should the legend at its core be based on contradictions, so that every interpretation would of necessity run itself to death against them, it would be pointless even to attempt an interpretation unless one would seek to prove that the incomprehensible is indeed incomprehensible. (Josef K. loses himself utterly in the development of his exegesis and finally is "too weary to be able to survey all the conclusions arising from the story.") Yet the parable, "Before the Law," seems to express more than those parables of which Kafka once wrote that they wished only to say that "the incomprehensible is incomprehensible."¹⁶ We see the dilemma of the man from the country in the fact that he stopped half way. He had neither the courage to enter into the Law on independent initiative, nor the faith to persist in unwavering patience until entrance should be granted him. "I have," writes Kafka at one time, "either too much or too little patience."

To be sure, we have represented only one aspect of the legend. However, the intensity of Kafka's composition rests on an ambiguity which cannot ultimately be resolved. Like Josef K., the man from the country is guilty and, at the same time, not guilty. We have sought in this presentation to focus on the aspect of the man's possible guilt through omission. The other aspect, namely the innocence of the man and the devilish intention of the doorkeeper, is more obvious and to date has found weightier attention in Kafka-interpretations. But it is the blending of both aspects, the constant shifting of one into the other, which creates that impenetrable fabric characteristic of Kafka's literary art. It is this quality that, in the last analysis, makes his compositions insoluble for the critical mind.

In conclusion it should be emphasized that Kafka's legend reflects in a most moving fashion not only the desperate situation of Josef K., but also the fate of Franz Kafka himself. Seen in this way, the

¹⁴*Ibid*, p. 94.

¹⁵*Prozess*, *op. cit.*, p. 211.

¹⁶Franz Kafka, *Beschreibung eines Kampfes*, Frankfurt am Main, 1954, p. 96.

figure of the doorkeeper appears as a symbol of all those powers which barred the author's way to a life of independence and personal responsibility. These powers consisted in the fateful emotional dominance of his father and the peculiar power of the city of Prague which would not release its son. "Prague does not let me go," he once wrote to a friend. "This sweet little mother has claws."¹⁷ Doubtless the figure of the doorkeeper is also a symbol of the city on the Moldava. Johannes Urzidil has pointed out that Kafka's doorkeeper is "a direct reflection of the porters of Prague who, in heavy cloaks, two-pronged crowns, beards and scowl, and with gold-studded staves, guarded the mighty gates of the palaces of the nobility."¹⁸

Kafka's legend of the doorkeeper reveals a second understanding, namely the deeper reason for the frustrating of the attempt to break through to life. This reason is Kafka's anxiety and the thought patterns it produces—the persistent gnawing doubt and the unceasing attempts at calculating. He is not able to take the risks which life necessarily demands. It is the fearfulness of the one seeking admittance which gives the doorkeeper the power to prevent entry. This fearfulness, Kafka's sworn enemy, stood as the invisible ally of the doorkeeper before the door to Kafka's life.

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¹⁷Franz Kafka, *Briefe 1900-1924*, Frankfurt am Main, 1958, p. 14.

¹⁸"Edison und Kafka," *Der Monat*, 13. Jhrg., 153, p. 53 ff.